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Sunro—Rebirth Pains Coming on Strong

Mine Willing to Co-Operate on Disposal of Mine Tailings

MINE MANAGER Charles Campbell Jr. examines a lump of old mine tailings above the high tide mark at Jordan River beach. The solidified material is like dried mud, similar to river silt with a greenish tinge. Suggested plan is to disperse future waste through wave action over a wide sloping bench extending two miles seaward.

By AB KENT
Business Editor

Charles M. Campbell Jr. feels a mine coming on.

Specifically, it's the old Cowichan Copper mine at Jordan River, now held by Dison Development Ltd. on lease from Cominco and financed by French-based international interests.

Charlie Campbell, a mining engineer, is general manager of Dison, and the driving force behind rebirth of the Sunro following a 2½-year hiatus.

Its intermittent life has been noted for production of good grade copper concentrates, it has abundant ore reserves indicated, lies within an area whose industrial fortune rises and falls with the lumber market.

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But it needs a pollution control permit to resume production because operations include annual dumping up to 1 million gallons of tailings slurry into the sea a half-mile from Jordon River community.

Controversy rumbles as residents, parksmen, conservationists, recreationists, administrators, Boy Scouts and sundry others on southern Vancouver Island sound their objections to tailings disposal on a natural beach.

Their point is well taken. No one wants a muddy, greenish-black muck pouring over an unspoiled West Coast beach, with possible risk of damage to marine life.

Neither does Campbell, who considers himself a conservationist. He is also a formidable and persistent advocate of mining, who may be remembered for his battle with authorities in the opening of Western Mines' property at Buttle Lake.

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That was a fight involving tailings disposal in the lake forming part of the Campbell River watershed and source of the area's domestic water supply. Western Mines won.

Application for the Dison tailings permit passed its first hurdle — the regional district administration — after an 11-week wait. The district, although having reservations about the disposal of mine waste in the proposed fashion, found no bylaws were contravened and gave consent.

The provincial pollution branch is now considering the bid and if a permit is granted a series of conditions must be met, conditions about which experience is still being sought, since this type of permit is relatively new.

There is precedent — recently at Utah Construction and Mining Co.'s Port Hardy project, and historically at Britannia Beach in Howe Sound — but scientific studies are lacking.

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Campbell thinks the Sunro can empty its mill effluent into Juan de Fuca Strait where there is constant washing and scrubbing action from waves and tide flow at a point just below the low tide mark.

When Cowichan Copper operated the mine at intervals between 1962 and 1968, tailings were dumped over a cliff and allowed to accumulate at the base where most eventually were washed away by the sea.

According to local residents, this cleansing took some time, during which the mine was inoperative.

But Dison's consultant recommends not only moving the point of outfall 600 feet eastward, where current is stronger, but extending the pipe down the cliff, burying it the width of the beach and securing the seaward end so that tailings slurry would always empty into water.

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Campbell points out a difficulty of accomplishing this would be the risk of exposing the outfall pipe to damage in heavy seas which bring in gravel, some rather large rocks, and many driftwood logs.

But the company is prepared to do the bidding of the pollution control branch.

"The important thing is that we enter into this thing in a spirit of co-operation," Campbell said. "We are as conscious of the environment and of the importance of preserving it as anybody.

"I'm a conservationist, but I believe in the intelligent exploitation of resources."

The alternatives to putting slurry into the sea are to create tailings ponds or to leave the copper ore undisturbed.

With something around $500,00 invested in mine rehabilitation so far, the prospect of 1.75 million tons of 1.2 per cent proven and probable ore ready to be mined and the possibility of another 2 million tons within easy reach of existing underground workings, it is unlikely the developer will abandon the project.

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Tailings ponds, where slurry is allowed to settle, require considerable area and careful construction to avoid contamination by leaching. Campbell is against ponds because the terrain would necessitate putting them on or adjacent to B.C. Hydro right of way or the Jordan River community.

Such "socially desirable land," thinks Campbell, is unsuitable for tailings disposal.

The pollution permit application states a maximum of 1 year would be disposed of. Campbell said this is misleading without the further knowledge that the solids contained in that mixture of water and fine particles would be no more than 500,000 tons, provided the mine operated at capacity.

The operating range may be closer to 1,000 tons of ore a day than the 1,500 tons a day capacity of Dison's underground mill.

Tailings material itself is like a mixture of black sand and greenish mud. The water that carries it away comes from natural drainage in the mine, and when settled out, according to one source, contains less than one part per million of copper, a tolerable limit for human consumption.

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The Sunro mine is a medium to small operation based on a 7,800-foot tunnel that intersects 17 known ore bodies of which only two or three have been developed. A reasonably long life is indicated, during which the mine can make "a significant contribution to the economy of the area," as Campbell puts it.

It can continue to be a profitable mine, employing 160 men, at copper prices below the current 50 cents a pound, the manager said.

With the go-ahead from the pollution branch, another $1.75 million will be spent on new equipment and other needs to put the mine into production by fall.

The French firm of Pechiney Development Ltd. is to provide all pre-production funds, then take 100 per cent of the profits until it recovers its investment. After that, Pechiney will share profits 60-40 with Crownex International Ltd., parent firm of Dison Development.

Although study is still being given to means of transport, it is possible the Cowichan system will be used, in which concentrates were trucked from Jordan River to a ship loading dock at Hatch Point, near Mill Bay.

Bank of B.C. Revenue Increases

VANCOUVER — The Bank of British Columbia Tuesday reported an increased balance of revenue in the first six months of its 1971 fiscal year of $56,704 over the same period last year.

An interim statement showed the balance of revenue at $492,784 compared with $346,080 in the first half of 1970. The bank's fiscal year begins Nov. 1.

Chairman and President A. E. Hall said in the report that the bank "is hopeful that a further improvement in earnings will be evident over the balance of the year."

The bank's statements showed that deposits totalled $132,578,791 at April 30, compared with $76,856,405 on the same date last year.

Loans at April 30 totalled $92.6 million compared with $48.3 million in the previous year.

Hall said he believes B.C.'s economic outlook is good.

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